Colour for your website and business

Yes, and that is precisely its trap. It is the safest choice, and so it is easy to get lost in it.

Blue is a colour that people trust because they see it everywhere. In banks, in technology, in hospitals and in offices. In a 2015 YouGov survey blue was the favourite colour in ten countries on four continents (23 to 33% of respondents). That is why it is often the first choice in business. This part is not a guide to what you must do. It is an aid to know what blue promises and how not to get lost among other brands.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help evoke **trust** and **calm**, but what mainly decides is still **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Blue can say, for example

"You can rely on us." "We speak clearly." "We are in no hurry." "It is calm here."

- **Trust and reliability.** Blue does not sound loud. It sounds sure. That is why brands where the customer entrusts money, data or health use it.
- **Competence.** A 2012 study (Labrecque and Milne) suggested that people more often perceive brands in blue as competent and in red as exciting. It is one study, not a law.
- **Calm and space.** It suits where you want to slow the pace and let the customer think.
- **Distance.** A cold blue can seem aloof, formal or corporate.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also act differently. A dark navy feels **sure and prestigious**, sky blue **open and calm**, turquoise **fresh and creative**, an electric blue **more striking and technological**.

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Simple tips

Shade by role

A dark navy for certainty and prestige, a light sky blue for openness and calm, turquoise for freshness and creativity.

A warm accent

Add a warm colour to blue (orange, coral, yellow) so that the brand does not seem like a bank. Orange is its opposite on the colour wheel, which is why they stand out together.

Legibility

For ordinary text a contrast of at least 4.5 to 1 is recommended (the WCAG accessibility rule). Dark blue text on white works well, light blue on white does not. Check the contrast before you put the colour on text or a button.

Cultural context

In Turkey and Greece blue protects, in India it is infinity, in England sadness. Before you set off into the world, find out what blue means for you and for them.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Consulting, education, voice and word

Blue suits professions that stand on speaking, writing and listening. Trainers, speakers, journalists, podcasters, translators, therapists. It can recall calm and clarity. Try a darker blue as the base and a warm accent for a personal tone. If a website is entirely in electric blue, it can seem more technological than human.

Finance, law and technology

Here blue is almost expected. Why. The customer wants reliability and clarity from you and blue is visually learned for them. The biggest risk is that you get lost among the others. A different shade from the competition, your own typeface or one unusual accent will help.

Healthcare and care

A light blue and blue-green can evoke cleanliness and calm. For some, though, also a hospital corridor and waiting for news. Ask customers what blue reminds them of before you give it a large area.

Water, travel and rest

Blue naturally connects to the sea, rivers, pools and the sky. It suits spas, swimming, accommodation, travel or services around sleep and rest. It helps promise calm and space. Just do not let it seem cold. Add wood, cream or a warm detail so that the guest sees that someone cares for them.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Hospitality and celebrations.** A cold blue can seem aloof where you want to invite people closer. A warm accessory, wood or photographs of people soften the tone.
- **Playful children's goods.** A light blue is pleasant, but whole rich areas can seem stark. Add playful colours.

Give important information clearly legible dark text.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the blue?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that blue means trust.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know blue from banks, apps and boxes. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Facebook (social network)**
  According to a 2010 article in The New Yorker, Mark Zuckerberg is red-green colour blind and said of blue (loosely translated) “Blue is the richest colour for me. I can see all of blue.” It is a story about why the colour was chosen, not proof that blue sells.
- **Tiffany (jewellery)**
  A light blue (turquoise blue) appeared on the cover of the Blue Book catalogue in 1845. Pantone produces it as a special colour with the number 1837, after the year the company was founded, and the company has had it as a trademark since 1998. The colour carries prestige here, not coldness.
- **Nivea (cosmetics)**
  In 1925 Nivea received new packaging, the blue tin with a white logo that we know to this day. Blue carries purity and trust here.
- **Ford (cars)**
  The blue oval first appeared on Ford cars in 1927, among others on the Model A. The blue background with white lettering was more striking than the earlier white emblem.

What they share is that blue carries a simple message. **Trust, certainty, calm**. And brands hold it for a long time and consistently. Success is not made by the colour itself, but by there being something behind it that people believe in.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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